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Abstract. This study examined Filipino corporate trainers' views on the effectiveness of gamification in onsite and online training. Using Clark and Braun's thematic analysis, eight trainers shared their insights into its impact on engagement, motivation, and reinforcement. Results showed gamification can boost participation and structure learning, but its success depends on deliberate integration of game elements and digital tools. This varied slightly between modalities, especially when involving inductive and deductive assessments. Trainers emphasized the importance of incorporating interactive activities, providing feedback, enhancing competition, and offering rewards to strengthen engagement. The study also identified the complementary benefits of online and onsite training when combined with gamification techniques in a human-computer interaction setup. However, a strategic approach is crucial when aligning gamification with learning objectives.

Keywords: Corporate training · Gamification · Human-computer interaction

1 Background of the Study

Organizations are continually exploring various online and onsite training strategies to enhance workforce skills and performance [9]. One approach is through gamification, which involves incorporating game design elements such as rewards, rankings, and achievements into training programs [10]. It has become increasingly prevalent in contributing to employee engagement and knowledge retention [22]. However, while widely adopted, gamification remains a strategy that has yet to be fully explored and developed.

Corporate training in the Philippines has continued to utilize both on-site and online training methods, even after the COVID-19 pandemic. This study examined how Filipino corporate trainers perceive the effectiveness of gamification in training programs. It also explored the challenges and opportunities that corporate trainers face when integrating and scaling gamification strategies, as well as how emerging technologies, particularly artificial intelligence, can contribute to these strategies and assess their adaptability within a corporate training landscape.

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2 Review of Related Literature

2.1 Corporate Training and Gamification

Digital change presents both opportunities and challenges for corporate trainers, necessitating enhanced communication, refined instructional design methodologies, and alignment with employees' preferred learning styles [25]. The trend toward corporate e-learning is emphasized as a means of increasing worker productivity and flexibility, supporting a well-rounded plan that combines online and traditional training methodologies [9]. A crucial area is virtual onboarding, where ensuring a smooth transition into corporate culture depends on effective communication, the formation of digital work connections, and the availability of appropriate tools [26].

Artificial intelligence (AI) is particularly revolutionizing corporate digital transformation by enhancing learning and development through personalized training, AI-driven coaching, and immersive technologies, while also optimizing human resource functions [16]. AI-powered corporate training aligns with Industry 4.0 standards by incorporating ethical principles such as accountability, privacy, and equity while leveraging systems theory, psychology, and economics to enhance training effectiveness and human-centered learning [3, 7]. Despite these training improvements, virtual learning still faces challenges with participation and teamwork, which can be mitigated by incorporating structured interactions and emotional intelligence components [24]. The application of virtual training enhances performance and creativity among employees [1].

Gamification incorporates game elements into corporate training programs and other learning and development interventions, boosting engagement that further strengthens learner motivation by providing feedback on small achievements, which helps keep professionals focused on their training goals [18]. It enhances training effectiveness by leveraging technologies such as AI, which can personalize learning, create adaptive environments, and improve employee performance [10]. Despite these outcomes, gaps remain in exploring the long-term effectiveness of virtual training, as many evaluations focus on immediate learning gains rather than overall behavioral changes and business improvements [19].

The integration of game-like elements engages employees, leading to improved learning outcomes through emerging methods that incorporate gamification into training programs [20, 22]. Common elements used in this design process include leaderboards, rewards, narratives, and personalization, which have become increasingly prevalent in redesigning educational and corporate onsite training to increase participation [6, 22]. This method has gained traction with advancements in technology, creating an immersive learning environment in a dynamic business setting [10]. Rapid digitalization requires trainers to adopt new approaches, particularly through visualization techniques, to enhance efficiency in skills training, as the current technology-driven workplace demands [23, 26].

2.2 Training Impact and Employee Development

Effective corporate design integrates various methodologies and perspectives from trainers to enhance employee development and performance [4]. Implementing pedagogical interventions effectively enhances employees' emotional intelligence, highlighting

its crucial role in enabling better teamwork and adaptability [14]. Connecting diverse people across departments and communities involves cooperative learning [20]. Therefore, trainers should stay updated as they facilitate cross-departmental collaboration and knowledge sharing [15, 17].

Given the direct impact of structured training programs on an organization's progress, training initiatives help employees refine their skills and behaviors, creating a more productive work environment [8, 12]. Training contributes to corporate entrepreneurship by enhancing employees' strategic decision-making skills and promoting innovation in business models and processes, thereby enabling them to remain competitive in the market [11]. In this regard, on-the-job training is crucial for developing employees' technical and managerial skills, allowing them to learn by performing key tasks, develop expertise under supervision, and acquire interpersonal and problem-solving skills for effective workplace performance [11, 13].

Meanwhile, advancements in digital tools and AI-powered systems further enhance the impact of training, as AI-generated negative performance feedback can positively affect employee motivation and improve performance more effectively than human-delivered feedback [21]. Learning management systems can provide structured feedback that helps improve goal setting and learning outcomes in corporate training [8].

2.3 Synthesis

A knowledge gap in corporate digital training and gamification stems from limited interdisciplinary integration, as current research lacks insights from the theoretical underpinnings of psychology, education, and ethics. While gamification strategies are expected to enhance corporate training, findings highlight the short-term benefits that limit the understanding of how these strategies influence employee engagement, motivation, and knowledge retention [8]. Understanding how gamification strategies can integrate into existing training systems may help maximize their potential and overcome resistance to change. Technological developments can serve as potential learning scaffolds for many organizations. The effectiveness and adaptability of technology-integrated gamification strategies in training, alongside conventional gamification methods, remain underexplored, particularly from the perspective of corporate trainers based in the Philippines.

3 Framework of the Study

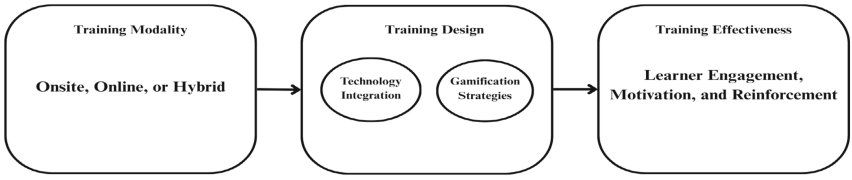


Fig. 1. Conceptual Framework of Filipino Corporate Trainers' Perspectives on Effective Training Programs.

Fig. 1 presents the variables using the Input-Process-Output model. *Training Modality* as an input captures the training delivery format options. It is the first element that influences the decision on which appropriate methodology to implement. When a training program is delivered in any of these modalities, each offers different advantages and constraints for the corporate trainers. However, this only sets the initial conditions for effective learning experiences. *Training Design*, which encompasses two complementary themes, presents itself as the transformation of the modality into practice. *Training Effectiveness* as an output is the result of the transformation, whether learner engagement, motivation, and reinforcement occurred.

3.1 Propositions of the Study

1. Integrating technology and gamification enhances the adaptability of corporate training programs across both on-site and online modalities by creating more engaging and compelling learning experiences.
2. Integrating game-like elements into corporate training programs can significantly enhance individual employee engagement and motivation, especially when combined with different training methodologies.
3. A well-rounded training plan that integrates technology-supplemented gamified activities fosters team engagement and social interaction in corporate learning environments.

4 Methodology

The study was conducted with eight Filipino corporate trainers through recorded Zoom video calls. Each individual in-depth interview lasted no more than 45 min. The chosen respondents have utilized gamification strategies in their programs and possess relevant experience in both onsite and online training modalities.

This study employed a descriptive and exploratory approach. For the descriptive aspect, the study describes the experiences, perspectives, and insights of Filipino corporate trainers regarding the use of gamification and technology in both onsite and online training modalities. It seeks to understand how they perceive the impact of these elements on various aspects of employee development. Furthermore, given the evolving nature of digital transformation in corporate learning and the growing focus on gamification within the corporate training industry, this exploratory study examines the nuances and complexities of these phenomena from the perspectives of Filipino corporate trainers. It seeks to uncover patterns, preferences, challenges, and even functional practices in the Philippine setting.

The research instrument used for this study is a structured interview consisting of four parts. Questions revolved around the participants' experiences with onsite and online training programs, the role of technology and gamification in corporate training, and their perceived impact on employee engagement, motivation, and learning reinforcement.

Given this, the study uses thematic analysis patterned from Braun and Clarke (2022), which involves an organic and comprehensive process: first familiarizing with the interview data by highlighting relevant keywords and quotations, then identifying codes

that were subsequently reviewed and collated into potential themes that meaning-based interpretative themes, rather than predetermined topic summaries, based on the gathered qualitative data from the interviews. Thematic analysis was employed over other types of qualitative data analysis to allow for flexibility in identifying patterns across the data while maintaining the depth of trainers' perspectives.

5 Discussion of Results

The study validated that gamification, supported by digital tools, has created more engaging and adaptable learning experiences. As supported by the corporate trainers, they observed higher participation when interactive elements were consistently integrated. Corporate Trainer 8 expressed, "*When I am able to make the program interactive and enjoyable, I notice that there's a higher level of participation and completion rate.*" Such responses highlight how the use of technology in modern gamification offers new heights of opportunities for gauging participation and performance. The same corporate trainer emphasized, "*because of technology and digitalization, training progress can now be more easily monitored and personalized.*" Corporate Trainer 2 specifically brought up the tools they often use like "*Mentimeter, Kahoot, and Google Slides*" at the same time emphasizing that, for them, "*breakout rooms in Zoom are very critical*" for encouraging group collaboration via online engagement. This sentiment extends across modalities, providing the convenience of remote learning, with Corporate Trainer 8 noting that "*digitalization has had a great influence positively on how I design my training programs for on-site training.*" This demonstrates that gamification augmented by technology crosses the boundary between online and onsite learning to create more effective and productive learning environments in both contexts.

Beyond implementation considerations, the study identified advantages unique with what technology-integrated gamification offers. Corporate Trainer 8 quotes that when "*participants can receive instant feedback, it helps them assess their progress and adjust accordingly.*" Rather than positioning online and onsite training as opposing approaches, determining which is better than the other, the findings suggest that they offer complementary benefits that can be combined. Corporate Trainer 5 expressed that "*there are pros and cons to both. And deciding on which mode to use depends on the client objective, as well as the learning objective.*" They further noted, "*nowadays, it seems there's no limit to what you can do really in training, whether it's on site or online, because of these technology advancements and digital integration.*" Given that, for future developments, participants showed enthusiasm for emerging technologies, with Corporate Trainer 8 predicting "*a strong shift towards highly personalized learning…with AI adapting the content and the assessment just to fit the individual needs.*" They also look forward to the possibility of how "*virtual (VR) and augmented reality (AR)*" will "*revolutionize experiential learning.*" This encourages corporate trainers and organizations to continually evolve and invest in their training programs to achieve better corporate learning outcomes. Hence, with the growing importance of technology in corporate training, it not only shapes how programs are delivered but also influences the tools and strategies that trainers utilize.

Building on this, the study identified the specific game-like elements that can foster both engagement and motivation among employees. Indeed, the integration of competitive, game-like features goes beyond entertainment purposes, as it can significantly influence and enhance the learning experience as well. One of the most common approaches of corporate trainers involves the use of point systems and prizes, whether in online or onsite training. Corporate Trainer 2 explained, "*I usually use point systems [onsite]…for example there's an activity and usually the organizations would have sponsorship on prizes. So definitely we need to craft points for those things so that at least they're motivated to enjoy the activity.*" Similarly, Corporate Trainer 7 highlighted the importance of incentives, stating that "*…the game-like elements that are most effective [online] would be incentives,"* which can include virtual rewards. These findings reveal how such reward systems can sustain employee interest and participation throughout a training program. However, it is important to note that the impact of these strategies was found to be often limited to the period of the training itself, as Corporate Trainer 4 pointed out, "*I'm not involved in the post-program already,*" which brings about questions regarding their long-term impact on employee behavior and development once the program is finished. In addition to points and prizes, elements such as leaderboards and competition were also noted for their role in driving employee motivation and performance. As Corporate Trainer 8 observed, "*…this helps me reinforce positive behavior and it keeps the motivation levels high…it adds a competitive element, so it drives the participants to perform better.*" The effectiveness of these game-like elements, however, seemingly depends on how well and purposefully they are integrated into the overall training design—combined with other methodologies or strategies. Corporate Trainer 5 specifically emphasized this point, stating that gamification is "*good to grab attention and to keep attention, but whether or not it can deepen the learning, I think it should be coupled with other strategies.*" The same corporate trainer also expressed apprehension about "*how gamification should be used for more in-depth learning rather than surface attention-grabbing objectives.*" Therefore, when designing effective training programs, it is essential for corporate trainers to avoid focusing exclusively on gamification strategies and, as Corporate Trainer 4 noted, ensure that they "*have a good mix of different methodologies that fit.*"

These methodologies require a well-structured approach to training and development plans. A primary consideration to this includes assessments that must cohesively tie to the gamified experience of participants, regardless of modality. Corporate Trainer 7 states, *"I would consider it as a structured learning experience…one activity and then there's a processing after. And then relating that activity to the bigger concept."* Processing activities ensure safeguards that check for understanding. These assessments of learning manifest in two distinct ways: through deductive and inductive learning. Deductive learning is crucial for information delivered explicitly by trainers. Interview 6 mentions, *"So right now, for us to know [if they understood a topic], we add some small assessments, short assessments, just for the topic adjustment."*

Meanwhile, inductive learning ensures that participants organically absorb the intended learnings from sessions, as mentioned also by Corporate Trainer 6: *"…the meat of most of my activities are done in group works. So, whether it be on site or online, they work on case studies, they share personal experiences."* Employing these different

assessments helps ensure training plans are deliberately well-rounded. As such, training sessions with cohesive training structures do contribute to positive team engagement. In the study, two major group types were distinguished: one for homogenous groups whose participants come from the same company, and the other a more heterogeneous mix of participants coming from multiple institutions. For heterogeneous groups, it was noted that learning should capitalize on the knowledge already acquired by the participants. Corporate Trainer 2 exclaims, *"…we believe that the knowledge is within the participant, and we need to draw out that knowledge so that at least they will be aware of it."* Corporate Trainer 1 supports this claim, saying that, *"[The activity] has to be familiar to them..it can't be overly complicated."*

Meanwhile, for homogeneous groups, it is crucial to leverage adjacent parts of the training management cycle. It is crucial to find opportunities to tailor training sessions to their organizational context. Corporate Trainer 8 shares, *"I would recommend organizations to start as usual by assessing the specific needs of their particular workforce, and the type of training that will best suit those needs."* Apart from training needs, it is also crucial to consider the post-session effectiveness of the training, as mentioned by Corporate Trainer 7: *"I ask them to have an accountability buddy who they will share their commitments with."* and that *"The last one would be action planning because unfortunately in training sessions it's just a one-off session, so after that I will no longer have visibility on whether they change their learning behaviors."* Measures such as using accountability buddies and action planning segments leverage the homogeneity of the group. All in all, these findings suggest that gamification plays a crucial role in encouraging active employee participation in both onsite and online training settings.

6 Recommendations

With Corporate Trainer 8's observation that *"when participants are able to receive instant feedback, it helps them assess their progress and adjust accordingly,"* corporate trainers should immediately and consistently use quick polls and verbal feedback in both online and onsite training to improve self-awareness of their progress and increase information retention. Furthermore, Corporate Trainer 2 specifically emphasized that these *"breakout rooms in Zoom are very critical"* for encouraging group collaboration via online engagement. Hence, within the next month, corporate trainers who conduct online training programs via platforms like Zoom or Microsoft Teams should maximize the use of breakout rooms, with clear tasks and reporting mechanisms to foster peer learning and enhance engagement in the virtual environment. Within the next one (1) to three (3) months, corporate trainers should integrate interactive gamification elements, particularly readily available digital tools like Mentimenter, Kahoot, and Google Slides, into existing training modules to boost engagement and provide immediate feedback on understanding, aiming for higher participation and completion rates—as Corporate Trainer 8 expressed, *"When I am able to make the program interactive and enjoyable, I notice that there's a higher level of participation and completion rate,"* and Corporate Trainer 2 mentioned using *"Mentimeter, Kahoot, and Google Slides."* Lastly, Corporate Trainer 2 explained using *"point systems [onsite]…so that at least they're motivated to enjoy the activity,"* and Corporate Trainer 7 highlighted that *"…the game-like elements that are most effective would be incentives."* Corporate Trainer 8 also noted that

competition *"drives the participants to perform better."* Therefore, corporate trainers and organizations' HR departments should design and pilot a system within two (2) months to acknowledge participation and achievement with low-cost rewards, such as public acknowledgement, digital badges, or small company-branded items, increasing motivation and engagement throughout the training program and fostering a competitive yet collaborative learning environment.

It is recommended that corporate trainers employ a well-structured, gamified learning framework that combines online and onsite training methodologies, given how Corporate Trainer 4 emphasized that *"Training programs must have a good mix of different methodologies…"* This strategy should carefully align specific workforce learning objectives and performance evaluations with game elements such as leaderboards, point systems, and incentives complemented with onsite methodologies such as team building and collaborative activities like role playing for better learning outcomes. This should be implemented within six (6) to twelve (12) months, with the assistance of instructional designers, digital platforms, and systematic post-training follow-up mechanisms. According to the corporate trainers interviewed, this type of integration promotes information retention, motivation, and employee engagement in a variety of ways, especially when gamification is purposefully planned and supported by collaborative exercises.

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